

Onboarding to first aha

Week 3, Lecture 2 · LangoBee to \$10K MRR

Summer 2026 · Operating a Solo Language App from Zero Revenue

What we'll cover

- Time-to-value: the clock starts at first session, not at signup
- The guided first session: one path, one outcome, sixty seconds
- Defining activation for LangoBee: word_lookup_opened as the aha action
- Measuring activation rate and what the benchmarks say
- Designing backward from the aha moment

Time-to-value

The clock starts before you think it does

Time-to-value is the elapsed time from when a user opens your product for the first time to when they experience its core value.

For a language app, the core value is: I understood something in my target language that I couldn't before.

The clock starts at the first page load. It does not start after the user finishes onboarding. It includes:

- The signup form
- Language selection
- Any tutorial screens
- Time waiting for content to load
- Time scanning the UI to find what to do

Every second is an opportunity to lose the user.

What "too long" looks like

LangoBee's June 2026 median session: 34 seconds.

If it takes 45 seconds to reach the first word tap under ideal conditions, then half of all users leave before they ever get there.

Industry benchmarks for time-to-value:

- Consumer apps: under 60 seconds to first value moment
- Language apps: under 90 seconds to first comprehension event
- Games: under 30 seconds to first score or win

The benchmark is not a ceiling. It is a floor. Faster is always better.

(Rachitsky, 2022)

The guided first session

A guided first session is an intentionally constrained first-run experience that removes every decision not needed to reach the aha moment.

Not: a tutorial that teaches features.

Not: a series of permission prompts.

Not: a profile setup wizard.

A guided first session for LangoBee:

1. Signup (or skip) - one screen
2. Spanish selected by default (editable later)
3. Feed opens on the highest-rated beginner video
4. A subtle tap prompt overlays the first word in the first caption
5. User taps the word. Popup opens. Aha.

Total target: under 60 seconds.

Defining activation

Activation is not signup

Activation is the earliest action that predicts long-term retention.

Signup is not activation. Signup means the user gave you an email address. Activation means they experienced the thing you are selling.

For LangoBee, the candidate aha actions:

- Session starts (too early: no value delivered yet)
- First video plays (early: value is possible but not delivered)
- word_lookup_opened (the aha: the user interacted with the learning loop)
- First word marked known (too late: requires multiple sessions)

word_lookup_opened is the right definition: it is the earliest action that requires the full product to work and delivers an immediate experience of the core value.

(Rachitsky, 2022)

Why word_lookup_opened is the right activation event

word_lookup_opened is the top product action in the June 2026 snapshot: 5,225 events in 30 days.

Users who fire this event have:

- Loaded the feed
- Watched at least part of a video with captions
- Seen a word they wanted to understand
- Tapped and received a definition

That is the full comprehensible-input loop. A user who completes that loop once has evidence that the product works for them. A user who does not complete it has no reason to return.

Measuring activation rate

Activation rate = signups who fire word_lookup_opened within 24 hours / total signups (real, bot-excluded)

PostHog query:

Funnel:

Step 1: user signed up

Step 2: word_lookup_opened

Conversion window: 24 hours

Date range: last 30 days

Exclude: founder account, test emails

Benchmarks from Rachitsky and Timen (2022): median 25%, mean 34%. Good: 30%+. Great: 45%+.

Run the query now. Write the number in your founder journal.

Activation is the earliest product action that predicts long-term retention
-- distinct from signup, which only confirms someone gave you an email address. (Paraphrased)

Lenny Rachitsky (2022)

How to Determine Your Activation Metric

Designing the path backward

Start from the aha moment and remove steps.

word_lookup_opened requires: a video is playing, captions are visible, a word is tappable.

Every step in the onboarding that does not contribute to those three conditions is a candidate for removal or deferral.

Common steps that sound necessary but are not:

- Push notification permission (defer to day 3)
- Profile photo upload (defer to week 1)
- "How did you find us" survey (remove entirely)
- Difficulty calibration quiz (set a default, let the algorithm learn)

Each removed step shrinks time-to-value. Each shrink improves activation rate.

(Hulick, 2013)

What to do with a low activation rate

Rachitsky and Timen (2022) report that a rate below 25% indicates a broken onboarding, not a broken product.

The diagnosis sequence:

1. Below 25%: fix onboarding first. The product may be fine; users are not reaching it.
2. 25-34%: improve the guided first session. Look at what activated users did versus non-activated users in the first 24 hours.
3. Above 34%: activation is acceptable. Retention (day-7 return rate) is now the constraint.

If `word_lookup_opened` has 5,225 events but most come from a small group of power users (the founder plus 3-4 real users), activation rate is misleading. Segment by cohort week before drawing conclusions.

Take-aways

1. Time-to-value starts at first page load, not after onboarding. Every second between landing and the aha moment is a leak.
2. A guided first session is not a tutorial. It is the shortest possible path to the first experience of core value, with every unnecessary step removed.
3. `word_lookup_opened` is LangoBee's activation event: the first tap of a word that delivers an immediate experience of the learning loop.
4. The activation rate benchmark is 25% median. Below 25% means fix onboarding before anything else.
5. Design the guided first session backward from the aha moment: remove every step that does not contribute to getting a video playing with tappable captions.

What's next

- **Reading:** "Week 3: The broken-vacuum bar and the guided first session" at `/c/langobee-10k-mrr-26su/readings/wk03`
- **Section this week:** Run the must-work checklist; design the guided first session script
- **HW1 (due this week):** Checklist results posted to Discord with all defects filed as GitHub issues
- **HW2 (out this week):** MVP-grade plus the cohort test: ship the guided first session and measure activation rate before and after